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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting (Part 1), Thursday, March 28, 2024

Date	Thursday, March 28, 2024
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	39m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cw1r6TIbN_U
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:00:04] Good morning. It's 9 a.m. and I will now call this meeting to order. As is customary for this board, we will begin our meeting with a moment of silence, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

[00:00:31] Okay, so we will move to the approval of the agenda. Is there a motion to approve the agenda

[00:01:15] as presented? Second. Mr. Sturdifant? Yes. Ms. Kilgore? Yes. Ms. Ashton? Yes. Mr. Hanson? Yes. Mr. rotherham yes dr northern yes miss holton i'm sorry what am i just agenda agenda yes and chair votes aye okay um and staff has provided us with the meeting minutes from our last meeting is there

[00:01:48] a motion to approve the draft minutes as presented to the board second mr sturdifant hi miss kilgore Ms. Ashton, Mr. Hanson, Mr. Rotherham, Dr. Northern, Ms. Holton, and chair votes aye.

[00:02:06] Okay, so this morning we have recognition of music in schools month and we have a special presentation before us today. And so if you would come up and introduce your, oh, I'm sorry, Ms. Holton, are you going to be doing the, excuse me?

[00:02:31] I am delighted today to recognize, invite the board to recognize March as Music in Our Schools Month, Theater in Our Schools Month, and Youth Art Month. And I am particularly pleased to recognize that we have some special guests today with us to help honor that moment.

[00:02:53] The board recognizes that knowledge and skills that students acquire through fine arts instruction include the ability to think critically, solve problems resourcefully, communicate effectively, work collaboratively, understand historical context, and exercise creative thinking by employing originality, flexibility, and imagination.

[00:03:13] The board adopted revised standards of learning for K-12 dance, music, theater, and visual arts in May of 2020. The standards emphasize the importance of fine arts instruction as part of a comprehensive education in Virginia public schools.

[00:03:29] And I'll take a moment of personal privilege to talk about the wonderful fine arts instruction that my own children received over the years in Virginia's public schools. Please join me in recognizing March as Music in Our Schools Month, Theater in Our Schools Month, and Youth Art Month.

[00:03:44] This morning, we will hear from a student quartet, Quattro Voci. I've got my pseudo-Latin right from Glen Allen High School in Henrico, Virginia. The group sings at major events throughout the year and recently finished undefeated during competition season.

[00:04:02] Congratulations. They received first place, a superior rating, and best vocal quality in the a cappella division at the Thomas Dale Choral Invitational. They received first place treble choir, a superior rating, and best vocal quality at the Kosti Classical Classic Choral Invitational.

[00:04:22] Finally, they received first place a cappella choir, a superior rating, and best vocal quality at the Hanover Festival of Choirs. Welcome, Quattro Voci, and we would love to hear from you now.

[00:04:54] just rolling on just rolling on because i'm queen of the world just singing a song like my god just glory hallelujah just for the parcel before i get ready to call just hopty-dopty i'm ready to walk

[00:05:24] Just rollin' along, rollin' along, just rollin' along, I'm sitting on top of the world, rollin' along, rollin' along, rollin' along, I'm a queen, but there was a song, rollin' along, just singin' a song, just singin' a song, just singin' a song, glory, hallelujah, I just

[00:05:52] The poor song is the poor. Get ready to fall. Just like Humpty Dumpty, I'm ready to fall because I'm singing on top of the world. Just singing a song. Just singing on top of the world.

[00:06:18] Move through a storm, hold your head up high and don't be afraid of the dark.

[00:06:56] At the end of our story, the golden sky and the sweet sun, walk on through the wind, walk on through the rain, though your dreams be tossed and flow.

[00:07:25] Walk on, walk on with hope in your heart and you'll never fall.

[00:07:53] When your time has been lost, hold your friends with care and their hearts give you strength To go on. At the end of the day, I know you'll be there.

[00:08:15] When I'm reading this morning, I'm finding one. Oh, walk on through the wind. Walk on through the rain. oh

[00:09:06] Thank you all so much.

[00:09:40] We are so appreciative of you being here with us to celebrate this wonderful March celebration that we have in the Commonwealth. And I know it goes without saying that that's a wonderful way for us to start our meeting today and really grounds us in what we are doing here today.

[00:10:00] So I'm very appreciative of that opportunity for us to have students here with us performing. So now we'll move to the public comment section of our meeting. And as stated in the board's bylaws, it's my pleasure to accept public comment on all matters related to public education in Virginia.

[00:10:20] But before we begin public comment today, I want to share a few comments about the manner in which public comment will be conducted. We ask that you model professionalism, dignity, and respect for others as you share your thoughts today. And as adults, it's important that we model respectful, civil public discourse for our students and children who are either in attendance today, as you see, or viewing this stream both now and in the future.

[00:10:46] When you begin, please provide your name or your role in affiliation. All of your remarks must be directed to the chair, not to any other individual. Speakers will have three minutes to share their remarks. You'll notice that we don't, I guess there's a timer up here.

[00:11:04] We're not in our usual space, so we had to make some accommodations. So you will notice that there's the timer on the screen. It will begin for your three minutes at green. At one minute, the screen will turn yellow. And then when your time is up, the screen will turn red.

[00:11:21] At that point, please close your remarks promptly. And speakers may provide your comments to Mr. Joe Crook over there, and we will certainly be passing them out to the rest of the board. All written comments received during the public comment will be collected and provided to us as soon as possible. Also, you can email a copy of your remarks if you so choose to Jim Chapman, our Director of Board Relations. And so with that, I will start with our list that signed up, and number one is Kathy Halverson, and then behind

[00:12:00] Kathy will be Douglas Hankison. Is Kathy here? Okay. Is Douglas Hankison here? Okay. Next is Alphibia. Okay. Delaware. Amy Griffin. And after Amy will be Sharon Fitz. Good morning.

[00:12:37] Well, good morning. President Creasy, Dr. Coons, and Virginia Board of Education members, Amy Griffin: My name is amy Griffin i'm the deputy executive director of the Virginia association of school superintendents i'm here on behalf of the vast board of directors and executive director Scott bray brand. Amy Griffin: To comment on a couple of items before you today and yesterday in your work session regarding the proposed new accountability framework for Virginia schools, I believe you received an email with these comments.

[00:13:02] item one growth waiting increase the growth waiting by creating model three for millen for elementary and middle. That has 50% mastery 40% growth and 10% readiness indicators fast continues to believe that growth is important in any new accountability system.

[00:13:19] While we had helped for growth to be weighted equally vast can accept a model three approach that it has 50% mastery 40% growth and 10% readiness indicators. Item 2: Readiness indicators for elementary and middle school need further development. We understand and accept the decision to include chronic absenteeism in the elementary and middle school indicators.

[00:13:41] However, the additional indicators for both elementary and middle school need additional development. For elementary school, we need clarification on what exactly performance tasks are that will be assessed. For middle school, we will request that there'll be a menu of additional indicators to choose from beyond chronic absenteeism, And those menu choices reflect best practices and middle grades education programming designs for the unique characteristics of young adolescents.

[00:14:05] Proposed focus on high school course work at middle school will exacerbate current inequities in high school course availability among school districts, as well as the current shortage of high school endorsed teachers at the middle school level. In addition, course completion of a single high school course may not indicate overall readiness for high school.

[00:14:22] Passing an end-of-course test does not demonstrate readiness for high school. It represents successful completion of a high school course. Item three, keep the GCI as our graduation indicator. As Vass shared with you at our January meeting, we are concerned about the feedback of using only the federal graduation indicator and dropping the graduation completion index for high school students.

[00:14:44] Dropping the GCI, which has served Virginia students for almost 20 years, eliminates the opportunity for students, especially students with disabilities, to have other certified paths to graduation, such as applied studies diploma and the GED. please keep the GCI as our indicator. Item four, no A through F for symbols, but create clear descriptive terms for school summative levels. Bass continues to strongly advocate against school summative levels that incorporate an A through F grading system for schools or a summative symbol based system. Bass does believe clear descriptive terms for school summative levels is the best way to communicate school success for our stakeholders. Item five, delineate specific supports and

[00:15:23] resources to school divisions beyond those that perform at the bottom five percent. We agree on need for supports for school performing in the bottom five percent those supports must be extensive and timely to school divisions we also want to see more specific information about video supports for schools who do not fall in the designation but who may need targeted assistance please consider expanding vtss resources as possible solution we look forward to continuing to partner with you on this important work it just turns you thank you okay um sharon fits

[00:15:58] Sharon Fitz here. Michael Karabinos. And followed by Michael will be Jeffrey Koop. Good morning. I'm Michael Karabinos. I am a parent in Chesterfield and I'm also here on behalf of Virginia Public Education Partners. It is said that every trans suicide is a homicide. I'll say

[00:16:33] that again. Every trans suicide is a homicide. What else could it be? Because we know how to prevent it. We know because our doctors and our psychiatrists overwhelmingly have been telling us us for decades, for a century, how to prevent trans suicide. It is through affirmation and acceptance we know. We know that rejection, oppression, and denial of the self causes trans suicide. So we know. And if we know how to prevent trans suicide, and we know what leads to

[00:17:12] trans suicide, and we choose a path that causes death, what else could that be called but homicide? Oklahoma schools chose the path of rejection and oppression and denial, and a life has been lost as a result.

[00:17:33] Virginia last year put forward a model policy that mirrors Oklahoma policies in many ways. I asked this board to choose life. I asked this board to withdraw the 2023 model policies designed by a manufactured moral panic fed by disinformation, designed for rejection, oppression, and denial, and returned to the policy prior to it that brought affirmation and acceptance.

[00:18:06] And I ask this board to choose life. And in light of lives, I'd like a moment of silence as I read some names of victims of policies, rejection, and oppression.

[00:18:45] Blake Brockington, Reboir Ibrahim, Alu Kansen, Eden Knight, Tristan Bustos, Armia Lewis-Daniel, Myo Mazuriski, Sharon, Celine, Matthew, Anaya, Cherry Valentine, Lucy Meadows, Daphne Dorman.

[00:19:24] Thank you, sir. Okay. Jeffrey Coop. Is Jeffrey Coop here? How about Deanna Lester? Deanna Lester.

[00:19:38] Olivia and Carter Mellon sorry if I said your name wrong good day thank you for taking time

[00:20:15] to listen to my public comment I have provided you with some information pertaining to my speech my name is Olivia Mellon and I'm from Norfolk Virginia I have been identified as both Oh, okay. Both gifted and autistic. In Norfolk, Virginia, we had a very interesting problem in our city government a while back involving the Norfolk Community Services Board. It turns

[00:20:51] out that an employee was getting paid for not working, and it added up to hundreds of thousands of dollars over 12 years. This is commonly called a ghost employee fraud. Somehow no one went to prison after this, even after it made national news. Years after that, I was under the Norfolk Community Services Board because of Norfolk Public Schools teachers. This funded me to a private school that serves children with specific labels, including emotionally disturbed, juvenile offenders, psychotic disorder, substance abuse, and sex offenders. This school had a built-in seclusion

[00:21:28] room, which was used to confine children without arrest or conviction. Now, there has been a state mandated committee for this kind of thing since 1993. It's called the Family Assessment Planning Team, and it funds private schools as well as foster care. The Community Services Board is legislated to be on that team. It is important for children and parents to know what state and federal agencies can bring civil and criminal action against this committee when it does not

[00:22:03] work properly correctly i do not know why i was funded to a school for criminals addicts and the mentally ill but i do know that the people that educate didn't have the money and the people with the money can't educate i need to know who at the state and federal level can fix this again thank you for your time i'm enclosing my father's contact information below i give this to you

[00:22:32] Thank you so much. Thank you so much for your time. Thank you. Okay, that ends our sign up list today. And so if there's anyone else in the public that would like to comment, please go ahead and line up behind the microphone, please, and make sure that you provide us with your name and

[00:23:08] your affiliation. Thank you. Good morning, everyone. My name is Dr. James J. Fetterman, president of the Virginia Education Association, a proud middle school music teacher from Accomat County located on the beautiful Eastern Shore. I'm here to speak on behalf of the VEA on the proposed changes to the accreditation and accountability system, item L. In the fall of last year, you conducted listening tours and your summary of that feedback in January stated that there were general agreement growths should be at least weighted equally to achievement, if not more.

[00:23:42] The proposed weighting system in item L to the board calls for the opposite, diminishing growth to a top range of 20 to 25 percent in elementary and middle schools, and not including it at all for high schools. This board has also talked extensively before about the importance of using growth to measure a school's quality to improve student achievement and not just reflect on the demographics by using raw pass rates. You as the board have the autonomy to listen to the feedback you received in the fall and your instincts and create a system that places the most emphasis

[00:24:17] on growth. It's critical in the development of a new performance framework to consider the end goal, which is for student achievement to improve because schools improve. Currently, according to JLARC, the Office of School Quality does not have the capacity to support schools that are not fully accredited with much more than additional paperwork and reporting.

[00:24:39] Given the reality, we understand and support the position of reserving intense support by the Office of School Quality for the federal minimum of the 5% bottom performing schools in whatever performance index is finalized. Virginia must move away from a system where we only have the capacity to place burdensome compliance reporting on schools not meeting state standards.

[00:25:01] In terms of the indicators within the performance framework, we should look see additional clarity on the performance task proposed for readiness at the elementary level at the middle school level we do not believe that proficiency on a single high school test level indicates readiness and additional options are needed for indicators we support the continuation of using the graduation and completion index at the high school level as it provides credit to schools for directing students towards applied studies diplomas and ged's given that graduation is so strongly linked to improved life outcomes we feel this critical indicator should have at

[00:25:38] least equally weight to mastery lastly i ask that you remove from the regulations of the language to assign schools into at least four performance categories on an annual basis a summative score such as a star rating star rating or letter grades would not provide the level of nuanced parents need to make informed decisions parents could easily be misguided by a summative score based on mostly mastery to enroll their students in a school with high pass rates but low growth as we've seen in other schools in other states the type of summative score may also contribute to worsening racial segregations in our schools i ask you not to incorporate a single summative

[00:26:16] ratings in our school thank you so much for your time and your attention to this matter thank you i love the timer it's taking me back to my high school debate days see if i've still got it okay hi my name is sydney mcgee and i'm the chief of education and intern development for the virginia Spaceport Authority. I was a teacher for a long time. I taught for seven years in the K through 12 space, and I've taught in both public and private schools, and I have some experience working in admissions as well. And the Virginia Spaceport Authority is a political subdivision of the Commonwealth of Virginia. We're based on Wallops Island, Virginia, where we own the

[00:26:55] Mid-Atlantic Regional Spaceport, or Mars for short, and we launched the Electron and Antares rockets out there. So I appreciate the opportunity to be able to briefly say that the cluster of aerospace organizations out at Wallops Island on the Eastern Shore are very excited about the Lab Schools Initiative because in the world of STEM, innovation and passion are two essential drivers for success, which for us means granting this country continued assured access to space.

[00:27:26] And we know that Lab Schools, when boiled down to their simplest terms, are about innovation and encouraging critical thinking, which are definitely things that we need in the aerospace industry. and in my experience children are naturally big dreamers and they naturally think outside of the box and lab schools are a really wonderful driving force that encourage that and schools are wonderful places like I mentioned I taught in them for a long time and sometimes we have to think outside of the box and traditional schooling to find some other pathways for students to get into STEM and other things so it's really wonderful that lab schools are stood up and supported by existing

[00:28:05] academic institutions, because that encourages students to start thinking about next steps in their academic journey and career paths even younger. And at VSA, we hire people from a variety of academic backgrounds, from people who have GEDs all the way up to PhDs. And by attending a school that's directly connected with a higher learning institution, students can hopefully be more likely to consider what pathway they should track themselves on in order to potentially become one of my colleagues in STEM in the future, hopefully. So, we are really excited at the Virginia Spaceport Authority and everyone else in the aerospace cluster is really excited because

[00:28:43] we know several of the lab schools that are coming down the pathway are kind of STEM-oriented and have a STEM focus. So, just wanted to express that. So, thank you very much. 30 seconds left. Thank you. Well, good morning. My name is Lou Fincher and I serve as the Senior Vice President and Dean of our School of Health Sciences at Emory & Henry College. I also have the pleasure to serve as the chair of our governing board for the planned lab school that we've

[00:29:21] entitled the Southwest Virginia Healthcare Excellence Academy Lab School, or HEALS for short. I want to thank Zach Jacobs for inviting me to be able to come here and participate in this public comment section of your agenda this morning. I'm here to provide comments on the importance and the need for the college partnership laboratory schools throughout the entire commonwealth as well as in my region of southwest virginia as intended the lab school initiative has led to the creation of many innovative programs with academic and career exploration and clear career preparation focus areas such as stem as was just mentioned health care teacher

[00:30:01] education and many many more i found that one of the greatest strengths of the college partnership lab schools is that it promotes a strong collaborative partnership between higher education institutions k-12 schools and the employers and industry leaders that that will create our workforce for the future this collaborative team breaks down the silos that typically exist between k-12 schools higher education institutions and then employers bringing us all to the table to collaborate on what is needed to serve our communities

[00:30:37] so lab schools provide innovative teaching and learning models that emphasize experiential learning career exploration and the development of career readiness skills but these programs also support economic development for our communities throughout the commonwealth providing solutions for workforce shortages providing students with the opportunity to explore and pursue a career pathway which will in turn promote students social and economic mobility the unique and innovative focus of lab schools enable these programs to meet the unique needs of their students and the local communities our southwest virginia heals program does just that in that we have

[00:31:14] identified a health care workforce shortage in southwest virginia and come together to prepare pro or to put together a program that will actually grow our own through a grow our own pipeline to help students identify health care careers and be able to match those into career opportunities in our region i want to applaud the board of education for your work in reviewing and approving the handful of quality lab school programs thus far, and I know you have several on your agenda today. I also want to say a special thank you to Governor Youngkin and Secretary Gadira for their

[00:31:50] support and leadership of this initiative, and certainly want to have a shout out to Andy Armstrong for his guidance and technical support to all of the applicants for lab school applications. Thank you. Thank you. Good morning, President Creasy, Vice President Hanson, members of the Virginia

Board of Education and Dr. Koons. For the record, my name is J.T. Kessler. I'm here representing the Virginia School Boards Association. VSBA would like to express our thanks to Dr.

[00:32:23] Koons for attending a screening of the Right to Read documentary in collaboration with the VSBA Task Force on Students in Schools in Challenging Environments at our offices in Charlottesville earlier this month. This was a powerful event that is continuing the dialogue amongst education leaders stressing the importance of student literacy and its impact on the growth and development of students. Yesterday, the board was presented with options for a new school performance framework. VSBA appreciates the work of the department and the due diligence of the board as this process has evolved. VSBA wishes to stress the importance of the growth measure

[00:33:01] in both the elementary and middle school models presented for the board's consideration. students arrive at our schools with varying degrees of mastery with the high percentage of weight dedicated to mastery combined with the low percentages assigned to student growth in both models presented to the board vsba is concerned these models will not accurately reflect the work our students teachers support staff and administrators are doing each day we are worried these models will reward schools and communities with resources while punishing communities in challenging environments. We would ask the board to reconsider

[00:33:39] these percentages by weighing mastery and growth on an equal level in its performance framework for elementary and middle schools. By failing to place a higher percentage of emphasis on growth, the use of a rating or summative method to communicate accountability results about our schools will have unintended consequences. We spoke last fall in opposition to an AF model, a series of stars, or word descriptor as labeling schools. We encourage the board to avoid such labels and develop a system that drives needed resources to schools in highest need based on

[00:34:15] measures in the performance framework. In conclusion, I appreciate the opportunity to speak with you today. VSBA appreciates the work you're doing and looks forward to continued dialogue as you work through this process. Thank you. Good morning members of the board, superintendent coons and others my name is todd truett i'm a parent of two school-aged children and i'm here today from arlington virginia i'm i'm here today to advocate for the board to include

[00:34:51] as a readiness factor at the middle school level the percentage of students who pass a high school end of course exam by the end of eighth grade my reasoning such a factor will provide a very strong incentive for school districts to one not only offer algebra by eighth grade but two help prepare kids in advance to successfully take algebra by 8th grade. Civil rights leader Bob Moses referred to the ability to take algebra by 8th grade as a civil rights issue. It's been a long-standing goal of the U.S. Department of Education and many organizations. That way, kids can take without

[00:35:26] doubling up geometry in 9th grade, algebra 2 in 10th grade, pre-calculus in 11th, and calculus in 12th. That math sequence is crucial for kids who are not only interested in STEM careers, but any quantitative field, such as economics or business.

[00:35:42] In the U.S., what schools are not offering algebra by eighth grade? Disproportionately, schools serving lower income or underrepresented minority students. States can require schools offer algebra in eighth grade. For instance, North Carolina, New York, and Texas do.

[00:35:58] I think the Virginia legislature should pass a law requiring it, too. But you all adding such a readiness factor also likely results in it being universally offered in Virginia. Florida has a similar readiness factor in its accountability measurements, and a survey by the RAND Corporation showed 99% of Florida middle schools offered algebra by eighth grade.

[00:36:20] Conversely, in the same survey in California, where such course is not required and there's no similar readiness factor, one-third of schools surveyed did not offer algebra by eighth grade. But just offering it is not enough. school districts need to start as early as possible to prepare as many kids as possible to take algebra by eighth grade the board of education adding this readiness readiness factor will provide that incentive notably kids with money are already being prepared in virginia in private schools and via tutors and private math supplement companies like kuman and russian math

[00:36:54] but for excellent public school algebra readiness efforts we can already look within virginia to Fairfax County Public Schools. One of FCPS's strategic plan's goals is to have as many kids as possible successfully take algebra by eighth grade. FCPS Superintendent Michelle Reed has spoken about how their algebra readiness efforts start in early elementary. She was recently favorably featured in the Wall Street Journal for such efforts. In sum, I urge you to make the percentage of students who pass a high school end of course exam by the end of eighth grade a readiness

[00:37:30] factor thank you very much thank you is there anyone else who wishes to speak before we close the public comment section of our meeting today okay thank you um at this time the board will go into closed session and i would would ask mr hanson to please provide us with that motion i move that the virginia board of education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes consultation with legal counsel employed by or retained by a public body regarding

[00:38:08] specific legal matters requiring a provision of legal advice by such counsel pursuant to section 2.2-371188 of the code of virginia and the legal counsel to virginia board of education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting can i get a second okay all in favor hi okay the board will now go into closed session thank you all